RUB - INTRODUCTION TO LITERARY STUDIES

Literary Studies Last-Minute Guide

English-only high-yield explanations, distinctions and course-specific corrections

END-OF-TERM MOODLE TEST
Tuesday, 21 July 2026 - 16:15 - GABF 04/613
Bring a tablet or laptop. The test must be passed for successful completion of the course.

How to use this guide tonight

Time	Task	Goal
20 min	Run the mixed diagnostic	Do not study first. Expose weak areas.
45 min	Narrative core	Narrator + focalization, story/plot/discourse, characterization.
45 min	Poetry core	Meter, sonnets, rhyme and rhetorical devices.
25 min	Drama essentials	Hamlet, Volpone, speech forms and irony.
30 min	Mock exam	Review every wrong answer immediately afterwards.

DO NOT SKIP POETRY
The official course schedule states that, in principle, everything discussed in class is relevant. Poetry also had an online self-test. The earlier chat assumption that Poetry might be excluded is not reliable.

Source priority: official Moodle feedback and course files > corrected learning section > historical chat.

1 - Narrative fiction: the core map

THE TWO-QUESTION METHOD
1. Who speaks? Inside the story = homodiegetic; outside = heterodiegetic.
2. Who perceives? Access to a character's mind = internal focalization; observable behaviour only = external focalization.

Narrator and focalization combinations

Pair	First	Second
Heterodiegetic + internal	Narrator outside the story	Information limited through a character's mind: 'John wondered...'
Heterodiegetic + external	Narrator outside the story	Only observable behaviour: 'John sat down and looked away.'
Homodiegetic + internal	Narrator is a character	Access to the narrating character's own perception: 'I was afraid.'
Homodiegetic + external	Narrator is a character	The passage restricts itself to observable facts. Unusual, but possible.

Story, plot and discourse

Term	Core idea	Exam question
Story	Chronological sequence	What happened first, next and last?
Plot	Presented arrangement	In which order does the text give us the events?
Discourse	The broader 'how'	Order, perspective, selection, presentation and language.

Information and reader effect

Term	Meaning	Cue
Mystery	Missing information	Who did it? What happened? Why?
Suspense	Uncertainty and anticipation	What will happen next?
Analepsis	Backward movement	Flashback to an earlier event.
Prolepsis	Forward movement	Anticipation or presentation of a later event.

2 - Characterization, time and presentation

Two independent characterization axes

Term	Question answered	Example
Explicit	Trait is stated directly	'John was brave.'
Implicit	Trait is inferred from evidence	John runs into a burning house.
Narratorial	Information comes from narrator	The narrating voice describes a trait.
Figural	Information comes through a character	Self-description or one character describing another.

COMMON TRAP
Explicit/implicit asks **how directly** a trait is communicated. Narratorial/figural asks **who supplies** the information. A direct self-description is explicit and figural at the same time.

Focalization and thought

Internal focalization	Information is restricted through a character's knowledge, feelings and perceptions.
External focalization	No direct access to minds; use the camera test.
Zero focalization	The narrator knows more than any one character could know.
Focalizer	The character or position through whose perception information is selected.
Free indirect discourse	Third-person narration blends with a character's idiom or unquoted thought.
Interior monologue	Thought is presented directly, commonly in first person.

Modes and temporalities

Modes of presentation	Report, description, comment and speech/dialogue.
Narrative comment	The narrator interrupts or frames the action with judgement or direct reader address.
Story time	Duration of events in the story world.
Discourse time	Time or textual space used to present those events.
Setting	Spatial, temporal and often social environment of the action.

OFFICIAL NARRATIVE ANSWERS
Oliver Twist: heterodiegetic - dialogue - implicit - narrative comments.
Hemingway: setting - homodiegetic/first-person narrator - character - theme.

3 - Poetry: form, rhyme and meter

Voice and meaning

Term	Meaning	Cue
Poetic speaker	Voice speaking in a lyric poem	Not automatically the poet.
Persona	Developed fictional role of the speaker	A distinct invented identity or situation.
Subject	General topic	Love, war, nature, death.
Theme	Idea or claim about the subject	Nature can restore human joy.
Tone	Attitude conveyed by a voice	Ironic, critical, admiring, melancholic.

Sonnet forms

Form	Structure	Pattern
English sonnet	3 quatrains + final couplet	ABAB CDCD EFEF GG
Italian sonnet	Octave + sestet	ABBA ABBA CDE CDE; sestet variants possible
Volta	Turn in thought or argument	Often between octave and sestet or before final couplet
Blank verse	Unrhymed iambic pentameter	Regular meter, no end rhyme

Rhyme patterns

Term	Pattern	Meaning
Cross rhyme	ABAB	Lines 1/3 and 2/4 rhyme.
Enclosed rhyme	ABBA	Outer rhyme encloses inner pair.
Couplet rhyme	AABB or AA	Adjacent lines rhyme in pairs.
Couplet	Two-line unit	Often, but not necessarily, linked by end rhyme.

Metrical feet

Foot	Stress	Sound
Iamb	x /	da-DUM
Trochee	/ x	DUM-da
Dactyl	/ x x	DUM-da-da
Anapest	x x /	da-da-DUM

OFFICIAL METER ANSWERS
'Swift of foot was Hiawatha' = **trochaic**.
'Woman much missed, how you call to me' = **dactylic**.
For this course, the simplified 7/8-syllable definition of trochaic tetrameter was marked **True**.

4 - Poetry: lines and rhetorical devices

Line movement

Term	Meaning	Exam cue
Enjambment	Syntax continues beyond line end	The phrase needs the next line.
End-stopped line	Syntax closes or strongly pauses	Punctuation is evidence, but syntax is decisive.
Caesura	Strong pause inside a line	The pause is not at the line boundary.

Core rhetorical devices

Metonymy	Replacement through association: 'the Crown' for monarchy; 'foam' for the sea.
Onomatopoeia	Sound imitation: buzz, bang, tick-tock.
Apostrophe	Direct address to an absent or non-human entity: 'O Death!'
Parallelism	Repetition of a syntactic or grammatical pattern.
Antithesis	Contrast or opposition in meaning between parallel units.
Chiasmus	Reversed order of corresponding elements: ABBA.
Personification	Human qualities or actions attributed to non-human entities.
Metaphor	One thing described in terms of another without 'like' or 'as'.
Alliteration	Repeated consonant sound at the beginning of words or stressed syllables.
Anaphora	Repeated word or phrase at the beginnings of successive units.

DO NOT CONFUSE
Antithesis = contrast in meaning. **Chiasmus** = reversed structure. The same passage may contain both.
Apostrophe = direct address, not punctuation.

Official Poetry quiz anchors

- Herrick: 'last line' = alliteration; placed/chaste = rhyme; muse/life = antithesis; reversed order = chiasmus.
- Shakespeare Sonnet 49: iambic pentameter - rhyme scheme - anaphora - metaphor.
- Gray's ode: apostrophe - parallelism - personification - anaphora.
- 'Foam' in Sir Patrick Spens = metonymy.
- The voice in a lyric poem = poetic speaker; a fictional role = persona.

5 - Drama essentials

Act	Major division of a play; normally contains several scenes.
Scene	Subdivision of an act; Hamlet 1.2 means Act 1, Scene 2.
Dramatis personae	List of characters printed before the play.
Stage directions	Non-spoken instructions concerning movement, setting, sound or performance.
Dialogue	Words exchanged between two or more characters.
Monologue	Extended speech by one character; others may be present and hear it.
Soliloquy	Extended private speech voicing thought, conventionally unheard by other characters.
Aside	Brief secret remark intended for the audience or one character.
Dramatic irony	The audience knows information a character does not know.
Tragedy	Serious conflict moves toward catastrophe, suffering or death.
Comedy	Conflict conventionally moves toward resolution or social reintegration.
Satire	Critical exposure or ridicule of vice, folly or corruption.
Pun	Wordplay exploiting multiple meanings or similar sounds.

Pair	First	Second
Soliloquy / Aside	Extended private thought	Brief secret remark
Blank verse / Prose	Unrhymed iambic pentameter	No regular metrical line organization
Dramatic / Verbal irony	Audience knows more	Literal words differ from intended meaning
Tragedy / Comedy	Moves toward catastrophe	Moves toward resolution or reintegration

COURSE TEXTS
Hamlet: tragedy, dialogue, soliloquy, blank verse/prose, pun, characterization.
Volpone: comedy, satire, dramatic irony, aside, gulling and the presentation of greed.

6 - Final corrections and rapid recall

Course-specific corrections

Trochaic tetrameter	The Moodle course marked the simplified 7/8-syllable statement as True.
Woman much missed	Expected answer: dactylic meter, not trochaic.
Oliver Twist	heterodiegetic - dialogue - implicit - narrative comments.
Hemingway	setting - homodiegetic/first-person narrator - character - theme.
Homo + external	Possible when an I-narrator reports only observable facts in a passage.
Prose	Language without regular metrical verse-line organization; it can occur in drama.
End-stopped line	A comma is not enough by itself; the syntactic unit must close or strongly pause.

25 rapid-recall prompts

#	Prompt	Answer
1	Chronological events?	**Story**
2	Presented event order?	**Plot**
3	Broader 'how' of storytelling?	**Discourse**
4	Narrator inside story?	**Homodiegetic**
5	Narrator outside story?	**Heterodiegetic**
6	Who perceives?	**Focalizer**
7	Access to a character's mind?	**Internal focalization**
8	Observable only?	**External focalization**
9	Flashback / flash-forward?	**Analepsis / prolepsis**
10	Missing information / anticipation?	**Mystery / suspense**
11	Direct / inferred trait?	**Explicit / implicit**
12	Narrator / character supplies info?	**Narratorial / figural**
13	Topic / claim about topic?	**Subject / theme**

#	Prompt	Answer
14	Voice / developed fictional role?	**Poetic speaker / persona**
15	Unrhymed iambic pentameter?	**Blank verse**
16	English / Italian sonnet?	**3 quatrains + couplet / octave + sestet**
17	Turn in a sonnet?	**Volta**
18	ABAB / ABBA / AABB?	**Cross / enclosed / couplet rhyme**
19	x / ; / x?	**Iamb / trochee**
20	/ x x ; x x /?	**Dactyl / anapest**
21	Association / sound imitation?	**Metonymy / onomatopoeia**
22	Direct address / repeated syntax?	**Apostrophe / parallelism**
23	Contrast / reversed structure?	**Antithesis / chiasmus**
24	Extended private speech / brief secret remark?	**Soliloquy / aside**
25	Audience knows more?	**Dramatic irony**

STOP RULE FOR TOMORROW

Redo saved mistakes, complete one mock exam, read this guide once, then stop. Do not add new topics immediately before the test.